

Interview Guide

A story-based discovery interview on how experienced developers fold AI coding tools into daily work: where it helps, where it breaks, and what it costs.

METHOD	LENGTH	FORMAT
Story-based	~45 min	Remote, 1:1

RESEARCH ASSUMPTION – HELD BY THE INTERVIEWER, NEVER STATED TO THE PARTICIPANT

For experienced developers, the main friction is not code-generation quality, but the hidden cost of deciding whether to trust the output, and the rework when it is almost right.

GOLDEN RULE

Ask for a specific story, not an opinion. "Tell me about the last time..." gets the truth; "What do you think about..." gets theory. After a question, stay quiet. Let the silence work, people finish the most interesting part on their own.

[01] Warm-up

3–5 min

- Thank them. Set expectations: about 45 minutes, real stories, no right answers.
- Ask for recording consent: "I will record this so I can rely on your exact words later instead of my memory. The recording stays with me, only for analysis. Is that okay?"
- "To start, tell me what you work on, your stack, and the size of your team."

[02] Context: how it works today

8–10 min

- Walk me through a normal coding day. At what point does an AI tool enter it?
- Which tools are open while you code? *Probe: which one for what?*
- When do you not reach for AI, even when you could? *Probe: why not in that moment?*

[03] Story deep-dive — the heart

20–25 min

Pull two stories: one where it worked well, one where you had to fight it. The second is more valuable.

- Tell me about the last time AI saved you real time on a task. Walk me through it step by step: what the task was, what you did, what happened next.
- Now the last time it let you down or went sideways. What happened? *Probe: how did you realize something was wrong? What did you do next?*
- When it hands you a chunk of code, how do you decide whether to trust it or check it? *Probe: on what signal? How long does that take?*
- Was there a time the output looked right, you took it, and it bit you later? *Probe: what did it cost to clean up?*
- Describe the moment it frustrates you most. What exactly?
- Have you built your own workarounds to make it usable? *Probe: where did they come from?*
- What does it look like when you review someone else's AI code, or your own a week later?

Push each story with "and then what," "why that way," "what did you feel in that moment." Do not fill the gaps for the person; if it is unclear, ask.

[04] Needs and desired outcome

5–8 min

Ask about outcomes, not features. Do not suggest solutions.

- If you had a magic wand and could change one thing about how you work with these tools, what would it be? *Probe: why that?*
- Picture the ideal: you hand over a task and it goes exactly right. What does that look like, and how is it different from today?
- What would have to happen for you to trust the output more? *Catch the criterion for trust, not a solution.*

[05] Wrap-up

3 min

- What did I not ask that I should have?
- Ask for a referral to one or two people with similar experience.
- Thank them.